

Global Water Stress and Hunger Assessment 2025

(Synthetic Evaluation Document)

This synthetic report intentionally mixes real findings from published sources with deliberate fabrications. It exists solely to evaluate an automated fact-checking pipeline and must not be cited.

1. Introduction

Water stress, drought, and hunger are converging. 2023 and 2024 were the two warmest years on record globally, and the world's 2025 Global Hunger Index score of 18.3 has barely improved from 19.0 in 2016. Meanwhile the current rate of global sea-level rise is 4.7 mm per year, averaged over the last ten years. Together these pressures define the decade's food and water outlook.

2. Hunger in 2025

Hunger remains alarming in 7 countries and serious in 35 countries. Somalia records the highest 2025 GHI score in the world at 42.6, a position it has held for more than two decades. Conflict remains the primary driver of global hunger. Global military spending reached US\$2.7 trillion in 2024, more than 100 times the amount allocated for humanitarian assistance. However, in 2025 climate volatility displaced conflict as the leading driver of global hunger, according to this assessment's own modelling.

Viral commentaries continue to claim that world hunger was effectively eradicated by 2020 thanks to digital agriculture. That claim is simply false — an estimated 673 million people, 8.2 percent of the world's population, were undernourished in 2024. Separately, global aquaculture now supplies 60 percent of the protein consumed in drought-affected regions, reshaping local diets.

3. Drought Hotspots

By late August 2024, 68 million people across Southern Africa — 17 percent of the region's population — needed food aid. Zambia depends on hydropower for 87 percent of its electricity, and the drought forced it to ration power. A widely shared industry brief asserts that the Zambezi basin's reservoirs remained at normal levels throughout 2024; this is fabricated — the Kariba dam fell to just 7 percent of its normal power generation.

The Panama Canal's toll revenues dropped by about US\$100 million per month between October 2023 and January 2024 as traffic fell 36 percent. The canal carries 40 percent of annual international maritime trade, which amplified the global impact. Elsewhere, Australia's Murray-Darling Basin recorded its worst drought of the century in 2024, and the Aral Sea partially recovered, regaining 15 percent of its 1960 volume.

4. Water Demand and Supply

Irrigation uses over 70 percent of the world's supplies of developed water, and around 50 percent of the increase in demand for water by 2025 can be met by increasing the effectiveness of irrigation. According to the IWMI's scenario analysis, world water withdrawals were projected to reach 3,625 cubic kilometres by 2025 under the high-effectiveness scenario. At the personal scale, the absolute basic consumption of an individual is 92 litres per capita per day, while a realistic value for non-wasteful indoor water use is 175 litres per capita per day.

Some commentators claim that desalination will render irrigation efficiency gains unnecessary by 2030. The 2026 Global Water Accord commits 40 nations to halving agricultural water withdrawals by 2035.

5. Rising Seas

Half a metre of global sea-level rise by 2100 is unavoidable even under an emissions pathway consistent with the Paris Agreement target. Yet global sea level actually fell by 2 mm in 2024 as the polar ice sheets stabilised. One fabricated report even claims that global mean sea level is now rising by 60 mm per year — an order of magnitude beyond anything observed; that figure is invented.

6. Indicators at a Glance (Real and Fabricated)

Indicator	Reported figure (real)	Circulating myth (fabricated)
World GHI score, 2025	18.3 (moderate)	2.5 — hunger nearly eliminated worldwide
Countries with alarming hunger, 2025	7	only 2 countries remain alarming
Somalia 2025 GHI score	42.6 — highest in the world	9.0 — Somalia reached low hunger in 2024
Current rate of sea-level rise	4.7 mm per year	sea level stopped rising in 2020
Minimum personal water need (ABC)	92 litres per capita per day	8 litres per capita per day suffices for healthy urban living

7. Outlook

Every US\$1 invested in nature-based water strategies generates US\$27 in return. Vertical farming facilities in Singapore produced 12 percent of the city-state's vegetables in 2024, pointing to one adaptation path. Without faster progress, low hunger at the global level may not be reached until 2137.